Arkade

COMPARABLES RESEARCH

Industry & Economic Development Report

Seven comparable programs across the U.S. and Canada that validate the model — with outcomes data, tracked metrics, and benchmark narratives.

Project: NW Arkansas Global Retail Innovation Initiative
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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

A proven category. An unclaimed position.

Structured soft-landing and commercialization programs for international and out-of-market companies are not a new idea — they are an established and growing category of regional economic development investment, present in major metros across the U.S. and Canada. Programs in Austin, Atlanta, Washington DC, Toronto, and others demonstrate measurable ROI: companies that enter through structured pathways at significantly higher rates establish permanent presence, create jobs, and generate local economic activity than companies navigating markets informally.

Northwest Arkansas has proven demand for this type of program — Plug and Play's supply chain accelerator, launched in 2019 with Walmart, Tyson, and J.B. Hunt as founding partners, demonstrated that global companies will come to Bentonville when there is structured infrastructure to receive them. What NWA has not yet built is a program specifically designed for growth-stage, internationally-oriented companies seeking a structured pathway to market entry, commercialization, and sustained presence — the precise gap this initiative addresses.

> This is not an untested concept. It is a proven category of economic development investment that NWA has not yet claimed. Every comparable metro that has built this infrastructure has seen measurable returns. Bentonville has everything those metros have — and more — but is ceding ground to more organized ecosystems every year without it.

Austin, Texas

Opportunity Austin — Global Launch Pad

Operator: Opportunity Austin (Austin Chamber of Commerce) | Model: Chamber-led public-private soft-landing

STRUCTURE

The Global Austin Launch Pad provides international companies with a low-risk, high-impact entry into the U.S. market through tailored support, strategic connections, and dedicated office space. The program is closely integrated with Austin's broader economic development infrastructure and operates under the Chamber umbrella.

Opportunity Austin has signed MOUs with international partners including Switzerland Innovation to formalize pipelines for global company recruitment.

OUTCOMES

- **400+ foreign-owned companies** now operating in the Austin region — a direct result of sustained, structured international business attraction
- The program serves as the entry point for international companies across technology, clean energy, and advanced manufacturing

> **Why it's relevant:** Austin is the most direct U.S. market competitor to NWA for attracting growth-stage tech companies. The fact that Austin has formalized a soft-landing program — backed by its Chamber, just as this initiative proposes — while NWA has not is a competitive risk the proposal should name explicitly.

Atlanta, Georgia

Georgia Tech Enterprise Innovation Institute (EI²)

Operator: Georgia Tech EI² | Model: University-anchored, cohort-based soft landing

STRUCTURE

Georgia Tech's EI² Global program runs cohort-based soft landing immersions — both virtual (7-week) and in-person — designed to equip international leadership teams with the legal, operational, and commercial foundations needed to enter the U.S. market.

OUTCOMES (SINCE 2018)

- 22 companies from 5 countries across 2 continents
- **15 of 22 companies (68%) successfully expanded into the U.S. market** — significantly outpacing informal market entry attempts

> **Why it's relevant:** Georgia Tech's 68% U.S. expansion rate is a powerful benchmark. It demonstrates that structured programming — not just introductions — is what converts international interest into economic presence. Atlanta also proves a non-coastal city can compete for global companies when it has organized infrastructure.

Washington, DC

DC Global Soft Landing Program

Operator: WDCEP + Office of the Deputy Mayor | Model: Government-backed, multi-partner

STRUCTURE

Launched April 2024, DC's program features two pathways: a physical presence pathway (flexible co-working, 20% below market rent) and an immigration pathway (cap-exempt H-1B via George Washington University). Partners include WDCEP, Golden Triangle BID, Penn West Equity District, and multiple chambers.

WHY IT'S RELEVANT

- DC's 2024 launch proves this category is still actively emerging — NWA is not late to a mature market, it is behind on a growing one
- The multi-partner structure closely mirrors the Chamber-Arkade partnership model being proposed

Bentonville, Arkansas

Plug and Play NWA — Supply Chain & Logistics Accelerator

Operator: Plug and Play Tech Center | Model: Corporate-backed startup accelerator

OUTCOMES

- 13 startups per cohort presented to Walmart, Tyson, J.B. Hunt, Georgia Pacific
- **BOPS** deployed with a major retailer; **Gatik** launched autonomous commercial operations for Tyson
- Expanded to health tech accelerator in 2024
- Global portfolio: $9B+ in funding; exits include Dropbox, PayPal, Lending Club

THE GAP IT LEAVES

	PLUG AND PLAY NWA	PROPOSED INITIATIVE
Stage	Early-stage startups	Growth-stage (Series A+)
Origin	Primarily U.S.	International / out-of-market
Need	Mentorship, MVP validation	Market entry, pilot conversion
Duration	Short cohort	6-month engagement
Outcome	Demo Day	Physical relocation, presence

Why it's relevant: Plug and Play is the strongest local proof point that Bentonville can attract and activate global tech companies. But it serves early-stage startups — not growth-stage, internationally-oriented companies. The proposed initiative fills the adjacent gap.

National — U.S. Federal Program

SelectUSA

Operator: U.S. Department of Commerce | Model: Federal investment attraction platform

OUTCOMES

- **$390+ billion in investment facilitated** since inception, supporting 265,000+ U.S. jobs
- 2023 Summit: 4,900 attendees from 83 international markets
- 2024 Summit: 5,000+ participants across 96 countries

WHY IT'S RELEVANT

SelectUSA demonstrates the scale of opportunity — hundreds of billions in foreign capital actively seeking U.S. market entry. The federal program creates demand but does not provide local delivery infrastructure. Regional programs like Land + Launch NWA are exactly what converts federal-level interest into local economic outcomes.

PART II: INTERNATIONAL COMPARABLES

Global benchmarks that set the standard.

Toronto, Ontario, Canada

Toronto Global — Investment Attraction & Soft Landing

Operator: Toronto Global (public-private partnership) | Model: Regional FDI attraction with integrated soft landing

ANNUAL RESULTS (2023/24)

- **44 investments facilitated**
- **5,527 jobs created** (2,647 direct / 1,317 indirect / 1,839 induced)
- **$217.5M CAD in tax impact**
- **$637M CAD in capital expenditure**
- 40%+ of jobs landed outside City of Toronto

CUMULATIVE (SINCE INCEPTION)

- **260 investments facilitated**
- **33,000 total jobs** (16K direct / 8K indirect / 9K induced)
- **$1.3B CAD in total tax impact**
- **$3.46B CAD in capital expenditure**
- 50+ soft landing program alumni

> **Why it's relevant:** Toronto Global is the gold standard comparable — the closest operational model to Land + Launch NWA at larger scale. 260 structured investments have produced 33,000 jobs and $1.3B in tax revenue. Structured investment attraction programs are not charitable spending — they are high-return economic infrastructure.

Toronto, Ontario, Canada

MaRS Discovery District

Operator: MaRS (registered charity / innovation hub) | Model: Large-scale innovation hub with commercialization programming

SCALE

- 1.4M sq ft facility — North America's largest urban innovation hub
- 1,200+ ventures, 120+ tenant organizations
- 150,000+ visitors annually, 2,000+ events per year

OUTCOMES

- **$2.4B in capital raises** (2020 alone)
- **Capital raises 45% larger** than national average
- **60%+ average YoY revenue growth** for portfolio companies
- Investment Accelerator Fund: **$75M deployed → $1.37B follow-on → 31 exits**
- Over a decade: **33,000 jobs, $11.5B revenue, $30B GDP contribution**

> **Why it's relevant:** MaRS demonstrates what happens when philanthropic capital builds the infrastructure for a long-term innovation ecosystem. Its charitable structure is analogous to the role WFF is being asked to play. Physical infrastructure + curated programming + capital access is the winning formula.

SECTOR CONTEXT

Retail technology — a more targeted mandate that strengthens the case.

No comparable metro has built a structured commercialization platform specifically for retail and supply chain tech companies seeking access to the world's largest retailer and its supplier network. The NWA ecosystem has accelerators for early-stage companies. It does not have a program for **growth-stage, internationally-oriented companies** that are past the validation stage and need a structured pathway to market entry, enterprise pilots, and sustained regional presence.

Demand is proven: Plug and Play came to Bentonville because the demand existed. The Walmart supplier network (1,100+ companies) represents a uniquely concentrated enterprise customer base no other metro can replicate. Companies like BOPS and Gatik achieved commercial traction through structured NWA programming — proving the conversion works when infrastructure exists.

PART IV: BENCHMARK DATA FOR GRANT NARRATIVE

Data points ready for use in the concept paper.

METRIC	SOURCE	DATA POINT
U.S. expansion rate	Georgia Tech EI²	68% of participants expanded into U.S.
Jobs per investment	Toronto Global	~125 jobs per facilitated investment (cumulative)
Annual jobs (44 investments)	Toronto Global	5,527 jobs (2023/24)
Tax return from FDI	Toronto Global	$1.3B CAD tax impact (since inception)
Capital raise lift	MaRS	45% larger than national average
Foreign companies	Opportunity Austin	400+ in Austin region
Soft landing expansion rate	CIC / Industry avg.	~30% open U.S. operations
Federal FDI volume	SelectUSA	$390B+ facilitated since inception
NWA demand (proven)	Plug and Play NWA	13 startups/cohort, expanded to health (2024)

PART V: KEY NARRATIVE TAKEAWAYS

Five frames for the grant narrative.

01

NWA is not pioneering a new concept — it is catching up on an established one.

Soft-landing and commercialization programs exist in Austin, Atlanta, Washington DC, Toronto, and beyond. These are proven, ROI-positive investments. NWA's absence from this category is the risk — not the proposed initiative.

02

The Plug and Play precedent is the strongest local proof point.

A Silicon Valley accelerator built an NWA program specifically because the demand existed. Arkade's program is not speculative — it is the next layer of infrastructure on top of a market that has already demonstrated pull.

03

Structured programs produce dramatically better outcomes than informal ones.

Georgia Tech's 68% U.S. expansion rate vs. ~30% industry average. Toronto Global's 33,000 jobs. Structure is the decisive variable.

04

The public-private, nonprofit-fiduciary structure is the right model.

Every major comparator — Toronto Global, Opportunity Austin, DC, MaRS — operates through a public-private structure with clear accountability. The Chamber-Arkade model mirrors best practice.

05

WFF's investment would be catalytic, not charitable.

Toronto Global and MaRS data demonstrate that philanthropic and public capital invested in this category generates tax returns, capital inflows, and job creation that far exceed the initial investment. This is infrastructure spending with measurable economic ROI.